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Barry Kernfeld

Barry Kernfeld is a jazz scholar, musicologist, and editor of the Grove Dictionary of Jazz. *He has also authored the book* What to Listen for in Jazz, *and a case study* The Story of Fake Books: Bootlegging Songs to Musicians.

Barry was interviewed via Zoom on December 16, 2020, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College and I'm very happy to have Barry Kernfeld with me. And I'm going to introduce you, I'm not sure this would be the order of how you think of yourself, but a jazz historian, an author, an expert on song piracy, and a saxophonist. Does that work?

BK: And an archivist these days. Yes.

MR: Yes, an archivist. Okay. Well it's a pleasure to talk to you and it's curious, we had an exchange twenty plus years ago and I was able to write a few entries for your *Grove* at that time. And I'm wondering, we could talk about that for a minute. I found a quote from you from the edition twenty years ago, and it said, no actually it was the more recent, yeah, twenty years ago. You and your staff were reminded daily of the elusiveness of truth.

BK: An appropriate comment in this current culture, eh?

MR: Yeah. How about that.

BK: Now that truth is lost altogether. But anyhow, sorry, I just went off on a tangent.

MR: No that's okay.

BK: Couldn't help it.

MR: I'm always happy to be timely. And of course there's no lack of jazz myths about things happen, and this person said that to that person. And I wonder if you can tell me how you sorted out all that, to the best of your ability?

BK: Yeah. And we're sorting it out all over again as we do the twenty year update to the Second Edition.

MR: Of the *Grove*, yes.

BK: Yes, we're working on that now. I would say that insofar as it's possible to check primary sources, which now with Ancestry includes a huge wealth of genealogical documents, and family blogs, family trees, things like that. So that helps sort things out. Musicians' unions reports, so-and-so traveled here, record company catalogues. And what we found doing the *Grove* because jazz is this small, small world of interlocking relationships. And what we did with *Grove* that I think no one else had done was to check everybody against

bands, where they played, look at the history of the clubs, look at the band lists, and when it disagreed you might get the same thing nineteen times and find the right one on the twentieth, and that the other nineteen were just copying from each other. We tried to cross check just exhaustively in every source that we could get our hands at, whether it's a written document, iconography, photographs. So that's part of your answer. I would like to say, you know, something about why. Because people might think that we're just fuss pots. You know like who cares if he joined in 1955 or 1956, or in fact he met, they met in 1955 in Berlin and then joined the group in Hamburg in 1956? And to an extent maybe it is fussiness, but I think for one thing jazz is obsessed, perhaps too obsessed, with precedents, with the originals and the copiers, with the innovators and the imitators. And if we're going to talk about stuff like that, if we're going to think that it's as important and maybe too important in my opinion. But if we're going to think if it's that important we better know, really, who did what when with whom. And not form a bunch of conclusions based on things that aren't true or just careless, not so much purposeful fictions but just carelessness gets copied and copied and copied and disseminates through liner notes, through interviews and so forth. That matters. I think relationships matter as far as the facts and getting them right. And I'm sorry it's been twenty years and I don't remember who it was but I remember I was working on one of the women in jazz and just couldn't make any sense of her biography until I realized that she had been putting herself forward as three or four years younger than she actually was, and that's why she was going, you know, "I can't remember the details, maybe it was in Buffalo with Al Sears or something like that." These people were classmates. They went to school together. Well that's not evident if you think they're three or four years difference in age. But if they're the same age and in the same city and they grew up together and they played together, that to me says something that goes way beyond factual fussiness into meaningful how this music was made and how these people learned it.

MR: Do you think that the fact that you're a musician contributed to the fact that this is so important to you?

BK: Sure. I'm not sure how to answer that question. I mean I was obsessed with jazz, so interesting question. I'm pausing here to think that the reason it's so important to me may have — I think the fact that I was a musician had a lot to do with *Grove* and my ability to write about music and decide if comments about the music were B.S. or not. But I think what you just asked has more to do with me being a kind of nerdy intellectual. And that it was important to me for those reasons, because there is to my mind this obsession in jazz with precedents. And if you're going to talk about precedents, who did what, who influenced whom, then you have to make sure it's based on truth and not on error.

MR: Well said. You reminded me that when I was fortunate to interview Phil Woods he was talking about himself and he said, "Well I'm not an innovator, I'm a craftsman. You know, I learned from of course Charlie Parker and others." But he didn't consider himself to be doing anything really innovative. Perhaps he added his own flavor to it but it sort of goes to what you're talking about. Who are the fountainheads of these musical styles?

BK: And to me this is, jazz has dug itself a very deep hole and is really in trouble by putting so much emphasis on this. I have a wide range of musical interests. I go to a lot of classical concerts. I hear fabulously creative interpretations of music that's been around for 200 years, for 400 years, for 600 years. And yet I've watched jazz people be so hung-up on always trying to be something new, always having his own sound, and so forth, that they end up being paralyzed. I think it's a big problem for jazz.

MR: And how much of it do you believe is connected to the rise in academia, in jazz education?

BK: Oh no, I think this dates from decades before that. I think it's a vision, it's a myth, it's an interpretation created by jazz critics very early on in the music as a way, as a really good handle, at that time, to write about it. Because it was continuously evolving up to the 60s, maybe the early 70s, jazz fusion. It was continuously evolving. There seemed to be a narrative that worked in describing it as a thread of this style leading to that style leading to that style. It was also a way that I feel the critics made themselves feel better about themselves because they were insiders and they knew the innovators and maybe some of the other people didn't know the innovators and were just enjoying the imitators. You know I think it was a way of really — a petty way for people who were not making the music to live in that culture.

MR: Ah — to live vicariously what others were doing. Do you recall what music you heard as a child that might have had something to do with your path in life?

BK: You know I sort of do and sort of don't. I remember my father gave me one of those clip-on unpowered radios. I don't know if you remember that. It just has an alligator clip, you put it on your lampshade next to your bed and it receives stations. So I must have been like eight years old or something, and I remember hearing jazz and being knocked out, and I don't even know what it was. I have a feeling it was probably Bobby Darin's "Mack the Knife" with the big band, because that was something that would have been played on San Francisco AM radio, gotten into mainstream enough that an elementary kid would hear it. But you know I always, from when I became conscious of music and developed my love for it, it was jazz and popular music. You know I could give you later dates than that of things that I specifically remember but I wasn't one of these three year olds that looked at the cello and decided that I wanted to play it and that was it.

MR: Do you recall if you had a discussion with your parents about life as a musician or trying to fashion a career in music?

BK: How can I say — I was a star student at an academic high school and before that at the lower levels, and was expected to do something very different than attempting to be a musician, which failed, or becoming a musicologist, which succeeded.

MR: Well you've had a long path and your path to being an author, was it influenced by reading the jazz critics that you were referring to, and other authors, and being dissatisfied with what they wrote for the most part?

BK: No I came to it from musicology, not from jazz. Right? I always had sort of two lives — and really from the age of early teens I was leading two lives as the star student and the underage kid who snuck out to hear music. And, "Oh yeah, Mom, I have a friend who has a car." You know like, no, I'm taking the bus at night to hear stuff in San Francisco you know. And I really led these two lives for six, seven, eight years before I found a way that I could put them together through musicology.

MR: Can you describe specifically what a night, taking a bus to hear some music was like for you? Were they nightclubs?

BK: So I'm too young to go to nightclubs, okay? It's, I think the most perverse thing about my life and career is that I wasn't 21 until 1971, which means I couldn't possibly have heard all this great stuff live. I was just there — you know turned 21, Art Blakey and the Messengers at the Keystone Korner in San Francisco with Bobby Watson. You know that's where I kind of jump into hearing it live. And so what we're talking about is a fantastic, unbelievable upbringing in rock music in San Francisco. From the age of 14 I went to everything. I heard the debut of Cream and Hendrix at The Fillmore. I went to the Monterey Pop Festival, to Altamont, as crappy as it was. I heard The Who four times you know. Hendrix doing a cover of Sgt. Pepper's at Winterland. It was all rock music and trying to play jazz on the saxophone but listening to rock music 'cause that's what I could go to hear live. And that was stuff that was originally at Longshoreman's Hall in the Marina in San Francisco in the time before The Fillmore got started. So you know, taking a bus down there. After that, the Avalon Ballroom and The Fillmore and then The Fillmore in another location downtown on Market Street. The Fillmore was in the Fillmore District, which is one of the African-American districts in San Francisco, and then it moved downtown to Market Street to a much more generic location. So yeah, I could go on and on. All right I'll tell you the most incredible thing. So there was a firehouse, a disused firehouse 2-1/2 blocks from our home. And I had a friend who was cutting edge everything you know. He was the first person with a skateboard, with a surfboard, unfortunately with drugs and really ruined his life. And he was just on top of

Coming to The Fillmore." And so he took me around to this firehouse where this band was rehearsing with Sears Danelectro amplifiers. And it was Big Brother and the Holding Company before Janis Joplin joined them. And so we would go up there and just listen to them doing these two-chord jams you know, two guitar jams, sorry, not two-chord jams.

MR: Okay. Probably one-chord, right?

BK: No, no, no, not necessarily. They were, I actually liked them a lot more without Janis. They were great improvisers and had really interesting two-line things going. So you know that was the kind of thing that I was able to hear.

MR: That's awesome. Did you distinguish at that time between white musicians in rock and black musicians in rock? Was there anything that made them different from one another?

BK: At that time there were almost no black musicians in rock. So no, there wasn't a distinction to be made. Hendrix was a real exception at the time. It was very, very much white music.

MR: Yeah.

BK: And Santana, you know, Latin.

MR: I'm reminded that, getting back to jazz now, recently I received a *DownBeat* and the title in bold letters was jazz — sorry, "Race Matters." And I said, wow, and I went over to my bookshelf, because I had saved this other issue from ten years ago from another jazz magazine, and I pulled it out and it was Nat Hentoff and the title was "Race Matters." And so I guess my obvious question was does race matter?

BK: Oh yeah.

MR: Okay. How does it matter in your eyes?

BK: How does it matter in my eyes? Well that's too big a question to answer, God, how do you even begin? See since I was very young I loved black music. There were — radio was entirely segregated. There were white stations and black stations. The black ones were KDIA and KSOL. And I started listening to that. It was a revelation. It wasn't something that most people in my circle would have ever listened to. I was asked to join a sort of rainbow soul band with — to be the saxophonist in a group that was Korean, Chinese, Mexican and African-American, and an Irish organist. It was a great cultural experience. I'm scared in something as sort of off the top of my head situation as a video interview to really answer that except in an anecdotal way, so that some of the things we did, so we did James Brown covers, we had a really good singer and dancer. And we played all over the Bay area from the most affluent University of California Law School reception, to a dance in the projects. And you'd do a dance in the projects and you're up there on stage playing, and there's 200 people, 200 kids in a line all doing the same dance coordinated together. And first of all you realize, oh, that's what this music is about. It's

role. This is functional music, this is culture, this is social interrelationships. And to see that was just an eye opening experience for an 18-year-old kid who grew up in Jewish culture you know. It was fantastic. And I think there are many other anecdotal instant answers like that of just experiencing life in ways in which musics of African-American origin had a cultural meaning that I didn't find elsewhere. It wasn't a split between music and life. I think another component of the answer that can go down a rabbit hole is that in spite of what I said about innovators and imitators and my apprehensions about carrying that too far, I do believe in this idea there are people who came up with these ideas and if you were to ask me who I thought were the 50 most important jazz musicians, probably 48 of them would be black. I think I would probably throw Metheny and Stan Getz in there, and I don't know who else.

MR: Okay. Well the more we talk the more I think we have in common, because I had a similar experience in growing up in Rochester with the kind of thing you're describing so I thank you for sharing that with me. You used the word "functional." And over my shoulder I have Count Basie and Lester Young and I think of them as playing, I guess, functional music. I mean people could dance to it, they took joy in it, it hit their solar plexuses perhaps more than their head. I'm not sure that's the way to put it but, so I'm trying to form a question, it has to do with current jazz and I'm wondering if there's any functionality left in it.

BK: Well I don't see how there could be because popular tastes have changed several times from the years in which, from the decades in which jazz was the functional music for American society. It was rock. It was hip hop. It was disco. Those are out of order, but it was a whole bunch of things. Rock & roll, since that era, and that's just practical what people like to do to hang out, what they like to listen to. Now it's not even live music anymore. What people like to listen to is DJs.

MR: Yes.

BK: So that's just — I mean hell, things end. It's just over.

MR: How does that make you feel?

BK: Well as I said, I regret that I wasn't a whole bunch older to have experienced that stuff in the clubs, but how does that make me feel? There was this great New York City exhibit on Rembrandt and all the disputes about what he painted and what he didn't paint, and this really cynical thing up on the wall, it said, "Every generation gets the Rembrandt that it deserves." And I'm thinking well maybe every generation gets the jazz that it deserves. It's just what we are. It's not a choice that we can make. I just love the opportunities that I've had to hear as much as I have. And one of the great things in this new twenty year update to the *Grove Dictionary* is the explosion of high quality jazz videos now available,

government broadcasting. They have these huge archive things, repositories of films and videos that are now being posted on the web for free because it's a national thing, it's not a commercial ownership thing. And I am seeing completely amazing performances that I've never seen before. So in a way I am now closer to that world than I ever was, if I can go and watch somebody, you know, what did I just see — Monica Zetterlund with the Bill Evans Trio at a rehearsal in 1966. They just knocked me out. One of the most gorgeous, perfect things I'd ever heard. And so hey, you know, there's plenty to hear to be happy. I don't need to have some sci fi fantasy of wishing I'd go back to the future and show up in a club in 1940. It would have been nice but it didn't happen.

MR: Well I don't have to ask that question now. Sometimes I do ask that question, of time travel, but you just took care of it already. So in your role as an editor you've done so much of it. I wonder if it's sometimes hard for you if there's an artist that really demands attention and of course should be included whether it's the book or the on-line edition, but you don't particularly care for their music. Do you recognize that you might need to hand this off to somebody else or does it affect the way you think about including them?

BK: I like to think that it would affect it only in a small way. There are things like that, it does happen. If I can hand it off I will, sure I'd be happy to have someone do it who is a complete enthusiast for it. But I think that is much less of a problem for *Grove*, where we're so concerned with the nitty gritty biographical and discographical and videographical details and bibliographical details, and not with say writing a book about them or writing a review of their record, which is a different kind of writing that I wouldn't dream of taking on if I wasn't the favorite. All right, here's an example. Joe Zawinul — well I'm sorry, except for "Birdland" he just bores me to tears. He's not a favorite. I have huge, wide-ranging loves in jazz. I have really eclectic taste. It's a great thing for *Grove* because there's so much stuff I like. But sometimes, yes, you're exactly right, there's somebody that just bores me. But I don't think that that handicaps very much writing a Zawinul *Grove* article. It's pretty clear how important he was, what he did, and why he was important, and that's what we want to see in a *Grove* article.

MR: Okay. Does the fact that the next thing's going to be an on-line edition, you literally don't have to worry about how heavy it's going to be, how many pages you're creating?

BK: Yes. That's a big factor. It takes off a lot of pressure because you don't have to worry about publication cost. And you want to show some editorial sense as far as proportion and consistency and you don't write 300 words about this person and 7000 about the next. You want to have a balance maintained, but you can add a lot of detail that I would have had to worry about twenty years ago and don't have to worry about now. If it's important I can put it in. I think the much bigger consideration now is it's no longer a

Online, a component of *Oxford Music Online*. Which means when we do Nancy Wilson, I just re-wrote her article that was maybe 350 or 400 words, now it's probably a thousand, I didn't count. Because we're no longer writing about Nancy Wilson as a jazz musician. We're about writing about Nancy Wilson as a jazz musician, as a popular musician, as an actress, as an entertainer on TV, as a host of the "Jazz Profiles" show, as a civil rights activist, as a member of the Minority Council on AIDS. We're writing about her life now. And it's way more interesting to do it that way, and it's a way to not have to worry about putting someone in a jazz box, not have to worry about if this guy has an article in the general *Grove Dictionary*, should he also have an article in the jazz one and should it be different, because they're all collected into one place now and it's really, it's a good thing.

MR: Well Nancy would be happy, wherever she is, because as you heard her say in the session we did that she didn't like to be called a jazz singer. She just felt she was a singer and let me choose what I want to do. I was so surprised when she said that the critics panned her record with Cannonball Adderley.

BK: I was astonished.

MR: Because that's my favorite record in the world.

BK: I was completely astonished. What were they thinking? I mean so those two tracks, "Save Your Love for Me" and "Never Will I Marry," okay, as a *Grove* editor you have to be brutal. I'm dealing with tens of thousands of people and hundreds of thousands of recordings. Sometimes I'll listen to something just once. Often I'll listen to something just once, because I don't have time to do it more than that. Sometimes I won't even make it all the way through just once, it'll be three minutes in and I'll say all right, it's pretty clear what this person's doing, another Benny Goodman imitator, I don't have to listen to this whole track. I got it. "Save Your Love for Me" and "Never Will I Marry," I listened to those over and over and over again. They're just perfect jazz.

MR: A student of mine just sent me —

BK: So yeah, I was flabbergasted.

MR: Yeah. A student of mine just sent me a wonderful album of a singer/trumpet player from Spain I think, Andrea Motis. And she did this, I know, me neither. And she did those songs like, oh God, and she copped the arrangements and the whole thing and I was so happy to hear it. I'm also, I can't get away from Cannonball for a minute, because he's like my musical hero. And when you approached in your book *Twilight of Bebop*, can you talk about Cannonball for a minute? That's a way open ended question.

BK: Yeah, that's a long time ago. That was my Ph.D. dissertation, that's what got me into this writing about jazz in a scholarly way. And I was writing about the Miles Davis Sextet

could be analyzed in some sort of useful way, which is all an introduction to say that I actually don't love his playing as much as I used to. I love his ballad playing but his beboppy stuff is too many notes and not enough space for my taste.

MR: Again, very timely that you said that because I just got a gift from a fellow jazz educator of Cannonball Adderley Transcribed Solos. And I was looking, you know, at page after page, there's not too many rests in there. But I want to pursue the thing about improvising a little bit because there's a quote from you, "The romantic notion that jazz is generated entirely spontaneously" and it makes me think of people who have asked me and I've heard them ask other people, "What is this thing they're doing? When they play the melody I like it when they play the melody and then they do this stuff. What are they doing?" If you're at a cocktail party and someone answers that like do you pretend your phone rings and walk away or do you try to answer it?

BK: I pretend my phone rings and I walk away. Sorry. I ducked that question. I could try to not duck the question if you really want me to.

MR: I really want you to.

BK: I think — books I haven't written — I think jazz would do very well to have a book about jazz as performance practice by analogy with Baroque music performance practice. I think there are a huge amount of unspoken agreed conventions in a jazz performance and these are brought to the table when people meet and this is why you have the jazz show go "Let me introduce the band" and then they introduce each other because it's the first time they've played together, and yet they sound great and the person who is not a musician comes up afterwards and says, "You guys sound terrific, how long have you been playing together?" "We just met." "How did you do that?" You know and the answer to how'd you do that is performance practice. Jazz is as deeply embedded with prior agreements coming to a performance as any music that I know. And that extends to techniques of improvisation. So maybe to talk about what you're asking me, it's not just improvisation but it's repertory, it's harmony and agreements about what sounds, what voicings are appropriate for jazz and what voicings are inappropriate. It's instrumentation and tone on instruments. What kind of a sound are you bringing to a jazz gig? It's rhythmic style, swing, Latin, rock-based, hip hop. There are all sorts of things that people bring into the performance that they have learned to do with others previously, a sort of endless chain, and how you go about improvising for a substantial swath of jazz includes that. There were sort of in the simplest explanation, licks, formulas, things that you use as a way to get started and embellish upon. You don't just come with a blank slate. I think Mingus made a comment along that line once, though I don't remember exactly what it was.

BK: Yeah, you've got to improvise on something. Yeah. And until free jazz came along and modal jazz with droning harmonies, until those musics came on to open up possibilities for other ways of creating that something that you improvise on, jazz was very much made of improvised melodies that were generated in response to a functional harmonic pattern that underlied, whether that was blues or a popular song, that lay underneath the — that form the structure of the performance on which they're playing.

MR: Okay. Well you can go get another drink now at the cocktail party. You deserve it, that was a nice response. I can't say that I'm a constant listener to current jazz but what I've heard of it, something you said about the conventions of it and what we expect and it seems that they — younger players are approaching the time in a different way now. I listen to the bass players and the drummers and a lot — they're not playing the time, they're playing against the time. And it's very creative. It's hard for me to latch on to I guess. I guess I'm a guy who needs a groove.

BK: Yeah I'm sorry, I don't actually know what that means or who you have in mind?

MR: Well for one thing it was the San Francisco Jazz Collective that — very accomplished, and perhaps my ears aren't just modern enough for what they're doing.

BK: No there's so many different things happening it's really hard to say. There's a huge infatuation with unusual meter. That's like almost — so as jazz education, you know, formulated itself as a component of universities this idea of playing in all keys became popular. You know can you do "Donna Lee" in every key? And I think that has now morphed into can you do "Donna Lee" in any meter? So that's a technical thing that is of just about zero interest to me. I don't care about that. But there are so many different things going on worldwide in jazz. It's impossible to make any kind of generalization along those lines. There's fantastically creative players and there's robots and everything in between in many, many different styles.

MR: What makes a robot?

BK: It's just something that got fostered as a component of jazz coming into the university and people focusing obsessively on pitch/scale relationships — you get this chord you play these notes. And on people focusing on technique rather than having technique be subsumed to making melody. Making melody should be the number one consideration. Technique should be at the service of it. And that's just — I mean so what — there's — I'm sure that's true in music for a very long time in many different disciplines. You know it's just that it's all more visible now because we have such efficient communications.

MR: Yes. It's still a big tent. I enjoyed reading about your research into fake books.

BK: Mmm. That was fun.

MR: Yeah, and then the reply I read from, I guess it was one of the key guys in creating the

BK: Yes.

MR: What's your take on — talk about a big question — copyright laws and infringement.

BK: Well I wrote this book *Pop Song Piracy* and the point of that is that there's a long history in America of people who own songs, people who are stakeholders, resisting any new alternative that would take away their money. And it's a battle that was fought over song lyric sheets, over fake books, cassette tapes, pirate radio, photocopying, MP3 files, streaming, it's an ongoing battle and it's the same story over and over again. FBI investigations, federal trials occasionally and often fines and occasionally even prison sentences. So what's my take on this? I understand it's a human thing to want to protect your money. It's very — it's a turf war. It's just kind of normal behavior that goes way, way beyond music and to many things in our life. I think that copyright is a poker game. Now a patent is granted. You apply for a patent and it's granted. A copyright is not granted. A copyright is a claim. And the only time that claim is ever verified or not is when a case is taken all the way to a judgement in federal court. And so everybody's playing this poker game, and often the winner is the person who has the lawyer with the most money and very occasionally there are cases that make it all the way and receive a judgement. I understand and appreciate the need for the Copyright Act of 1909 and how well it protected songwriters and gave them an income. But the world has changed so much in 111 years that this very imperfect method has become distorted to the point where it's doing much more harm than good. The Fair Use clause has very much gotten lost. University libraries are finding themselves in terrible straits acquiring basic music tools because things that were available are now withdrawn because to disseminate them electronically is different than to disseminate them in print and those opportunities are being canceled. I could go into details but it's just too big. I have lots of friends who are music librarians, I operate in that world. It's kind of the bibliographical nerd world of *Grove*. And they're having a lot of student problems providing materials for their students and this is a component of copyright. So I think it's always been an imperfect game and it's just gotten really warped and is doing more harm than good, but God we've got another two hour conversation here if we actually talked about specifics.

MR: Okay. It's sort of an oxymoron because all this delivery, the methods keep improving and at the same time they're trying to put restrictions on what you can do with it and so forth.

BK: Well it was very interesting about *The Real Book* and this is a good example of the ways in which say 1973 or '75, whenever it was, was no longer 1909, the way the world had changed. There was a huge resistance to fake books, to publishing bootleg copies of notated jazz songs because that infringed upon the publishing rights, the royalties that went 50% to the composer and 50% to the publisher. But what Steve Swallow told me is

Michael Gibbs to Pat Metheny, Swallow himself, Carla Bley, and so forth, who have these tunes in *The Real Book*, and he said the upshot of this was that these tunes, many of whom became part of the repertory, they were recorded over and over again and the recording royalties that they earned swamped, were hugely more, than anything that they ever would have collectively made from print versions had those tunes been published as sheet music.

MR: That's positive. Didn't they call that the "butterfly effect?"

BK: I don't know that.

MR: Yeah. Okay. Somehow it trickled up to them I guess. Well I have asked you some really big questions so I'll try a bigger one. It's not a music question but I'm interested in what's your thoughts about the current state of our country and what we can look forward to.

BK: When I was a hopeful person in the 1960s I never imagined things could be as bad as they are now, that there would — I think we're moving towards a sort of culture of bullying. And I am astounded by the vast number of Americans who believe that power is more important than democracy, and who believe any absurd fantasy sci fi conspiracy theory that tickles their fancy. It's very, very depressing.

MR: I read in the *New York Times* recently a number of quotes about the arts have never been more important than they are now. Do you — would you agree with that statement? I mean I would like to but I'm not sure.

BK: Well I think it's certainly true in the schools, and it's sad the extent to which the arts in the schools are the first to go when funding for education diminishes. More broadly it's not something that I've given meaningful thought to.

MR: Okay. What makes you angry these days?

BK: Oh I wouldn't say that I'm an angry person ever. You've got to push my button pretty hard before I'm an angry person. I would say that almost everything in the news makes me an ostrich, I just want to stick my head in the sand, because it feels hopeless.

MR: Okay. No one has said that before, and it's an effective way of saying it. So on a lighter note, back to your online edition you're working on of the *Grove*, how do you know when it's done, or will it ever be done? Can it be updated as you go along?

BK: There is a good and a bad to this. The bad part of it is there will never be an other edition. And an edition is an entity in itself, it has guiding principles, it has consistency, it has an outlook, it has an overall vision. Now everything is piecemeal and ongoing. That's bad. The good thing is an edition is overwhelmingly difficult. I'm now 70 years old, it's a luxury to be able to do piecemeal at my own pace, to do it — the small things well and not worry about the big picture, to not have the pressures of a budget and a schedule, to

something that I intellectually approve of. But there isn't — I don't have the energy anymore to do a third edition of the *New Grove Dictionary of Jazz* and I don't think it would be appropriate anymore because of what we were talking about, because there are such a small number of people now who are jazz musicians in the same way that they were in the twentieth century. The norm now is post-modern cross-genre participation in many, many things. And many of the most creative people, even if jazz is a component of what they do, I would not call them jazz musicians. Some of them yes, some of them are still doing that and it's really clear that they fit into that model of what we think jazz is. But that's a pretty hard living these days, and it's not of interest to many of the most creative people who are now living.

MR: Okay. Well I'm going to wrap up here, this has been fascinating. One question I wanted to get in that's very relevant to us, when we have our interviews my wife has done all these transcriptions. And I learned that you did a lot of transcribing of the Smithsonian interviews. And we were curious, the logistics of how did you do that? Were they on cassettes or were they reel to reel tapes?

BK: No this was much later. This was all on CDs. This was like — I don't remember exactly the years but after 2000. Early 21st century so it was all, it was very easy. It was all on CD.

MR: Well I want to thank you for your career. I mean I consult the *Grove* a lot and I love books, so it's a win-win. And it was quite a labor of love I think for you and well worth doing, in addition to all the other things you've done. I saw one picture on your website of you with a clarinet. I think you were on "Fiddler on the Roof." Do you still play your instruments?

BK: No that all sort of evaporated simply a period of life kind of things. We had a wonderful jazz group for almost fifteen years and I consider that a blessing to have a group last that long. But eventually you know, in a college community people move away and when it got to the point where we no longer had a chordal instrument we just couldn't keep going anymore. And similarly I discovered late in life that I was much more talented as a musical theater performer than as a jazz musician. It's something I didn't know but the ability to switch instruments quickly and to read really well and the experience of jazz was important because I could — I had such a good knowledge of the repertory and I could know how to play with people and hear when something happens and so when the singer dropped out a verse I could go right with her. You know, and everybody'd follow Kernfeld, he knows where he is. You know. But that was something late in life that I enjoyed a lot and I had, you know, six different instruments that I could play in the pit. But that fell apart too for various just reasons, it slowly evaporated over the years. Last

year I played two musicals for one week each and this year none. So it's all done. Unfortunately. It was fun. It was fun while it lasted.

MR: Yes. I'm in the same position with gigs you know. If I could play them I would but it's not happening now so I'll do more reading. All right so I'm going to pause our recording and I want to thank you for our time today, it was very, very interesting for me.

BK: Thanks, Monk, it was fun.